

Make Ableton Live

Remix Videos

With an Akai MPK mini

A beginner Ableton Live manual for Kiffness-style video remixes on Mac

MPK -> Live Clips -> Arrangement -> Synced Video

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Codex with ChatGPT 5.5

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1 Start Here: What You Are Learning

You want to make videos in the spirit of The Kiffness: take a memorable source clip, find the musical hook inside it, and build a funny, tight, danceable arrangement around it. The Akai MPK mini is a good controller for learning this because it gives you keys, pads, knobs, and simple performance controls in one small desk instrument.

This manual assumes you are new to the MPK, MIDI, Mac audio, recording, mixing, syncing to video, and DAW workflow. It explains the pieces from zero and then turns them into a practice system.

The three reference videos for study are:

- The Shira Choir x The Kiffness - Im Hashem Lo Yivneh Bayis (Psalm 127 DANCE REMIX): <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=EGmXAu8geVg>
- The Kiffness - Ievan Polkka ft. Bilal Goregen (Club Remix): <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=CAyWN9ba9J8>
- The Kiffness x Ognjen & Sinisa - Insomnia (Balkan Club Remix): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=hVJtPuuQK_s

Respect copyright and permission. Use your own recordings, licensed samples, public-domain material, collaboration footage, or source clips you are allowed to remix. Learn the method, not unauthorized copying.

2 Kiffness Lessons

This chapter turns the on-screen MPK layer captions from Kiffness videos into practice studies. Each lesson is not a promise that the original track used exactly these sounds or mappings. It is a beginner-friendly way to recreate the visible idea on an MPK mini: assign pads, play simple keys, move one or two knobs, and record the layers in an order the viewer can follow.

Use the same default MPK map for every lesson unless a lesson says otherwise:

Control	Default job
Pad 1	Kick or main downbeat
Pad 2	Snare, clap, or rim
Pad 3	Closed hat, ride, or shaker
Pad 4	Extra percussion or tom
Pad 5	Source chop or vocal hit
Pad 6	Harmony or response chop
Pad 7	One-shot effect or transition
Pad 8	Stop, mute, or outro hit
Keys	Bass, chords, lead, piano, organ, pads
Knob 1	Track volume for the active part
Knob 2	Low-pass filter cutoff
Knob 3	Reverb send
Knob 4	Delay send

Film each study as short proof of process: source clip, first layer, second layer, then the payoff. The captions are useful because they teach the viewer what changed.

2.1 Hard Work

Reference: The Kiffness x Sergeant Major Christian - “Hard Work”

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=5y5yRKhanLQ>

On-screen layers: bass, keys, ride, snare, guitar, kick, toms, muted trumpet, open trumpet, trumpet stab, organ.

Build this as a marching-band pop sketch.

1. Set the project tempo by tapping along with the cadence.
2. Put kick on Pad 1, snare on Pad 2, ride on Pad 3, and toms on Pad 4.
3. Record a two-bar drum loop with kick and snare first; add ride only after the groove feels steady.
4. Play a short bass line on the keys. Use one octave and mostly root notes.
5. Add keys or organ with simple stabs on the offbeats.
6. Record guitar as a muted pluck sound if you do not have a real guitar.
7. Put muted trumpet, open trumpet, and trumpet stab on separate software instrument tracks, or use three presets from one brass plugin.
8. Caption each new layer when it enters, then cut to the source cadence for call and response.

MPK focus: use pads for the military rhythm and keys for bass/brass. Use Knob 2 to close the organ filter during the buildup, then open it on the final chorus.

2.2 Thai Pile Drivers

Reference: The Kiffness X Thai Pile Drivers - Work Shanty
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=dlho15QNPbE>

On-screen layers: fast tambourine, beat, bass, keys, pads.

Build this as drum and bass from a work rhythm.

1. Find the repeated work-hit rhythm in the source and loop one or two bars.
2. Put kick on Pad 1, snare on Pad 2, and fast tambourine on Pad 3.
3. Turn on Note Repeat for Pad 3 at 1/16 notes to make the tambourine fast and even.
4. Record the beat with a strong snare on beats 2 and 4.
5. Play a short bass line on the keys. Keep it punchy and repetitive.
6. Add keys with a bright pluck or piano patch.
7. Add pads last with long chords underneath the source.

MPK focus: Note Repeat is the lesson. The tambourine should feel mechanical enough to turn the work clip into a dance groove.

2.3 A Jazzy Glove Compartment

Reference: The Kiffness x A Jazzy Glove Compartment
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=DtuZJrwkosY>

On-screen layers: ride cymbal, bass, piano.

Build this as a tiny jazz trio.

1. Set a relaxed swing tempo.
2. Put ride cymbal on Pad 3 and record a light swing pattern.
3. Play walking bass on the lower keys. Use root, fifth, passing note, octave.
4. Add piano chords on the middle keys. Two-note shell voicings are enough.
5. Leave space for the source sound; do not overplay.

MPK focus: velocity. Tap the ride softly and play bass notes at different strengths so the loop does not feel like a grid exercise.

2.4 Big Billy

Reference: The Kiffness X Big Billy
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=T0P6MC8Ris8>

On-screen layers: shaker, beat, bass.

Build this as a simple cat-voice groove.

1. Loop the source phrase until the downbeat feels obvious.
2. Put shaker on Pad 3 and use Note Repeat at 1/8 or 1/16.
3. Put kick and snare on Pads 1 and 2, then record the beat.
4. Play a bass line that answers the cat phrase rather than covering it.
5. Keep the arrangement sparse; the joke needs room.

MPK focus: restraint. Three layers are enough if the source phrase is strong.

2.5 Alugalug Cat

Reference: Alugalug Cat X The Kiffness

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=kG2JvYSqGR4>

On-screen layers: beat, keys, bass, 1st harmony.

Build this as a soulful singing-cat response.

1. Chop the cat phrase into one main call and one shorter answer.
2. Put kick, snare, and hat on Pads 1 to 3.
3. Record a beat that leaves the call uncluttered.
4. Add warm keys with two or three chords.
5. Play bass under the chord roots.
6. Sing or sample a first harmony and place it on a new track.

MPK focus: use keys for harmony first, then bass. If you only have one take, record chords, duplicate the MIDI region, and simplify the copy into bass.

2.6 Oh Long Johnson

Reference: Oh Long Johnson x The Kiffness

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=4efpoO5PWps>

On-screen layers: snare, hi-hat, kick & snare, darbuka, bass & mute guitar, keys, trumpet, trumpet harmonies, 1st vocal harmony, pads, 2nd vocal harmony.

Build this as a reggae/world groove with stacked responses.

1. Put kick on Pad 1, snare on Pad 2, hi-hat on Pad 3, and darbuka on Pad 4.
2. Record snare and hi-hat separately so the viewer can see the groove grow.
3. Add kick & snare as the full drum payoff.
4. Play bass on the lower keys and a muted guitar skank on the upper keys.
5. Add keys as short offbeat stabs.
6. Record trumpet as a simple melody, then duplicate it for harmonies.
7. Add vocal harmony in two passes: first harmony, then second harmony.
8. Add pads quietly under the final section.

MPK focus: separate layers even when they could be recorded together. The video lesson is clearer when “snare,” “hi-hat,” and “kick & snare” are visible steps.

2.7 Pipeline Funk

Reference: Armin Kupper - Pipeline Funk

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Gmo5-STWF4M>

On-screen layers: hi-hat, bass, cats, vibe, pads & vibe cat.

Build this as a funk loop around a melodic source.

1. Put hi-hat on Pad 3 and record a tight 1/16 pattern.

2. Play a syncopated bass line on the keys.
3. Put a small cat sample or vocal response on Pad 5.
4. Add a vibraphone or bell patch for the “vibe” layer.
5. Add soft pads underneath and blend them with the vibe sound.

MPK focus: use Knob 3 for reverb on the vibe layer. It should shimmer without washing out the bass.

2.8 Lalala Dog

Reference: The Kiffness x Lalala Dog

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Wcl1Z0bBoBE>

On-screen layers: beat, shaker, vox 1 & bells, vox 2 & organ, bass, outro.

Build this as a bright vocal-pop loop.

1. Make the beat first with kick and clap on Pads 1 and 2.
2. Add shaker on Pad 3, preferably with Note Repeat.
3. Record the first vocal response with bells. Use a bell preset on the keys.
4. Record the second vocal response with organ chords.
5. Add bass last so it locks to the full vocal rhythm.
6. Put an outro hit or final sample on Pad 8.

MPK focus: pair a vocal layer with an instrument layer. “Vox 1 & bells” and “vox 2 & organ” teach arrangement by pairing timbres.

2.9 Feira de Mangaio

Reference: The Kiffness x Mariana Merenda - Feira de Mangaio

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=8IeU79NpcU8>

On-screen layers: kick, clap x2, guitar, bass, trumpet, cowbell, shaker.

Build this as a Brazilian-flavored acoustic dance study.

1. Put kick on Pad 1, clap on Pad 2, cowbell on Pad 3, and shaker on Pad 4.
2. Record kick alone first.
3. Record clap x2 as two quick claps around the backbeat.
4. Add guitar with a real guitar, a sampled guitar, or a short pluck patch.
5. Play bass with short notes that move around the kick.
6. Add trumpet as a simple answering phrase.
7. Add cowbell and shaker only after the main groove works.

MPK focus: make the percussion conversational. The cowbell and shaker should answer the vocal, not simply fill every empty space.

2.10 Waqoba Amaqatha

Reference: The Kiffness X The Joy - Waqoba Amaqatha

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=dExvQB7CtFg>

On-screen layers: shaker R, clap, pads, clap x2, clap x4.

Build this as a vocal-group remix with escalating claps.

1. Pan shaker slightly right for “shaker R” and record it with Pad 3.
2. Record one clap on Pad 2.
3. Add long pad chords on the keys.
4. Record clap x2 as a two-hit pattern.
5. Record clap x4 as a faster fill leading into the chorus.
6. Keep the source vocals dominant; the MPK layers should frame them.

MPK focus: use one sound three ways. A single clap becomes a groove, a double, and a four-hit fill through rhythm alone.

2.11 Axel F

Reference: The Kiffness x Damat Drummer - Axel F / Crazy Frog

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=p6C-4LXTmPU>

On-screen layers: bass, lead, sauce, synth, vibe, butterfly.

Build this as an electronic novelty hook.

1. Play the bass on lower keys with a short, rubbery synth preset.
2. Play the lead on upper keys using a bright square or saw lead.
3. Make “sauce” an effect macro: filter movement, delay throw, or pitch bend.
4. Add a second synth layer with a wider sound.
5. Add “vibe” as chords, bells, or a soft pad.
6. Make “butterfly” a playful one-shot: a riser, pitch swoop, or chopped vocal.
7. Record Knob 2 and the joystick during the sauce and butterfly moments.

MPK focus: macro performance. This lesson is less about realistic instruments and more about making the controller look and sound alive.

3 The Kiffness Method

The method is not “put a beat under a video.” It is closer to a musical reply. The source clip stays the star. Your job is to reveal the song hiding inside the clip.

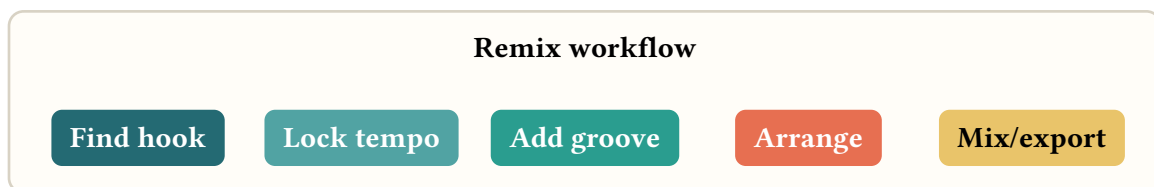


Figure 1: A source clip becomes a remix by moving from hook to tempo to groove to arrangement.

Watch the reference videos for these ingredients:

Ingredient	What to notice
Source hook	A voice, phrase, rhythm, or visual moment that is immediately recognizable.
Groove translation	Drums and bass make the source feel like a track.
Call and response	The source says something; the music answers.
Build and payoff	Layers enter in a way the viewer can follow.
Performance evidence	Hands, face, instruments, or DAW moments show the remix being made.

Your beginner goal is not to imitate every detail. Your goal is to finish short studies: 15 seconds, 30 seconds, then one minute.

4 What the MPK mini Is

The MPK mini is a MIDI controller. It usually does not make finished sound by itself. It sends instructions to software on your Mac: note on, note off, velocity, pad hit, knob movement, pitch bend, modulation, and timing features.

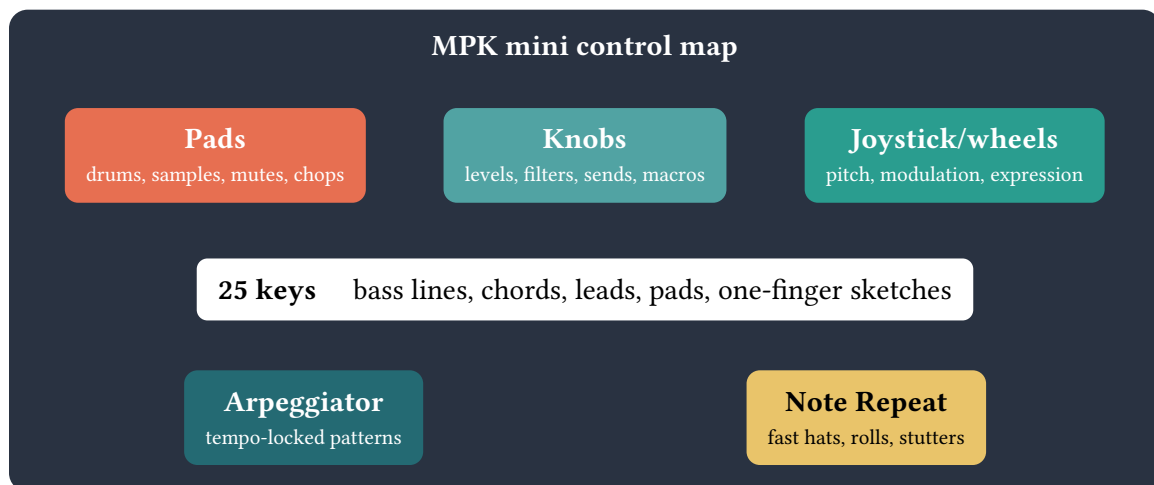


Figure 2: Treat the MPK as a performance surface for the DAW, not as the whole studio.

MPK part	What to use it for
Keys	Bass, chords, synth lines, piano parts, pads, and hooks.
Pads	Kick, snare, hats, percussion, samples, source chops, and transitions.
Knobs	Track volume, filter cutoff, reverb send, delay send, panning, and effect macros.
Joystick or wheels	Pitch bend, vibrato, filter movement, and expressive synth moments.
Arpeggiator	Rhythmic note patterns from held notes or chords.
Note Repeat	Repeated pad hits in time with the project tempo.

The most important beginner distinction: the MPK sends MIDI, while your DAW and plugins create audio.

5 MIDI and Audio Without Confusion

MIDI is control information. Audio is sound.

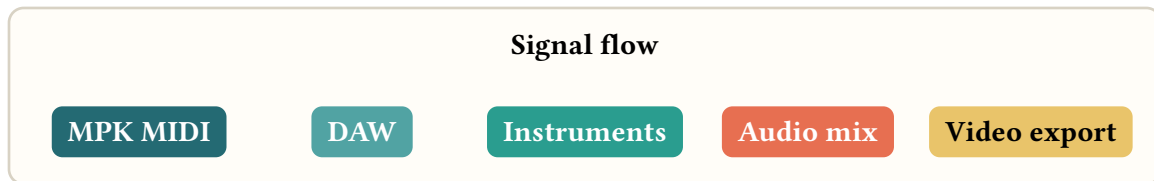


Figure 3: MIDI controls software instruments. Audio is recorded, mixed, and exported.

Term	Meaning
MIDI track	Editable instructions: notes, timing, velocity, knob movement.
Audio track	A recorded waveform: voice, guitar, source clip, or exported beat.
Instrument plugin	Software that turns MIDI into sound.
Effect plugin	Software that changes sound: EQ, compression, reverb, delay, saturation.
Latency	Delay between playing and hearing. Use wired headphones and low buffer settings.
Buffer size	Audio setting: small buffer for recording, larger buffer for mixing.

If you see MIDI notes but hear nothing, load an instrument. If you see an audio waveform but cannot change its notes, remember that it is already sound, not MIDI.

6 Mac Setup

Start simple. Do not buy ten things before you can make one loop.

1. Plug the MPK directly into the Mac over USB.
2. Open Audio MIDI Setup in Applications > Utilities and confirm the device appears.
3. Pick one DAW path for the project. The interactive tutorials in this manual use GarageBand only. Ableton Live and FL Studio are kept as separate subsections so new DAWs can be added without widening comparison tables.
4. Use wired headphones. Bluetooth latency will make timing feel broken.
5. Create a project folder with Source Video, Audio, Stems, Project, Exports, and Notes.

Gear	Recommendation
Built-in mic	OK for rough ideas, weak for final audio.
USB audio interface	Best next purchase for microphones, guitar, and lower-latency input.
Closed-back headphones	Prevent playback from leaking into a mic.
External monitor	Useful, not required. A laptop screen is enough for early projects.

7 Your Physical Rig: MPK, MOTU M4, Pre-73, and Mics

Your rig has two separate worlds:

- MIDI control: MPK mini to Mac over USB. This controls software instruments.
- Audio recording: microphones and preamps into the MOTU M4, then into your DAW.

Keep those worlds separate in your head. The MPK does not plug into the MOTU for this workflow. The MPK plugs into the Mac. The MOTU handles audio.



Figure 4: MIDI goes directly to the Mac; microphone audio goes through the M4.

7.1 Three Safe Connection Choices

Use case			Cable path	Phantom power
Condenser	mic	through	Mic XLR -> Pre-73 mic input -	Turn 48V on at the Pre-73.
	Pre-73		> Pre-73 line output -> MOTU	Keep MOTU 48V off.
			M4 rear line input 3 or 4	
Dynamic mic	through Pre-73		Mic XLR -> Pre-73 mic input -	Off, unless the mic specifi-
			> Pre-73 line output -> MOTU	cally requires phantom.
			M4 rear line input 3 or 4	
Mic directly into	MOTU		Mic XLR -> MOTU M4 front	Use M4 48V only for con-
			input 1 or 2	denser mics. Keep it off for
				dynamics/ribbons unless the
				mic manual says otherwise.

The Pre-73 is a preamp. If you use it, the cleanest beginner path is to send its line output into one of the M4 rear line inputs. That avoids running a preamp into another preamp. If you must use an M4 front combo input, keep the M4 gain low and watch the M4 meter carefully.

7.2 Power-Up and Power-Down Order

Use this order every time until it becomes boring.

1. Turn monitor speakers down or off. Put headphones on the table, not on your ears.
2. Confirm phantom power is off on the Pre-73 and M4.
3. Connect the mic.
4. Connect Pre-73 output to M4 line input if using the Pre-73.
5. Connect M4 to Mac over USB.
6. Open Ableton Live and select the M4 as input and output.
7. Turn on phantom only if the mic needs it, and only on the device feeding the mic.
8. Bring gain up slowly while speaking or playing.

9. If anything clips red, turn down the earlier gain stage first.
10. Before unplugging a condenser mic, turn phantom off and wait about 10 seconds.

7.3 Gain Staging With the Pre-73 and M4

Gain staging means each device receives a strong signal without overload.

Stage	What to do	Watch
Pre-73 input gain	Raise until the mic feels present. More gain adds more preamp color.	Pre-73 meter should not live in overload.
Pre-73 output	Use it as the level sent to the M4. Lower output if you drove the input for color.	M4 input meter.
MOTU M4 line input	Prefer rear line input 3 or 4 for Pre-73 output.	Avoid red on the M4 meter.
Ableton audio track	Arm the correct Ext. In pair and record.	Peaks around -12 dB to -6 dB are healthy.

For a clean vocal, use moderate Pre-73 gain and enough output to feed the M4. For a more colored vocal, raise Pre-73 gain and lower Pre-73 output so the M4 still receives a safe level.

7.4 Monitoring on the MOTU M4

The M4 can let you hear inputs directly, before Ableton latency. Use direct monitoring when the delay bothers you while singing or playing.

Situation	Monitoring choice
Recording vocal through mic	Use M4 direct monitoring if Ableton monitoring feels delayed.
Playing MPK software instrument	Monitor through Ableton; MIDI instruments must be heard from the software.
Overdubbing voice over beat	Balance Ableton playback and live input so both are comfortable.
Mixing	Turn direct monitoring off if it doubles the input sound.

8 Installing and Checking the MPK

The exact menus vary by software, but the pattern is the same: the Mac sees the MPK, the DAW enables it as a MIDI input, and an instrument track receives the notes.

8.1 GarageBand

GarageBand is the path used by the interactive tutorials in this manual. It is the simplest place to learn the MPK as a performance surface because it starts quickly, records software instruments cleanly, and keeps the timeline easy to read.

1. Connect the MPK over USB.
2. Open GarageBand and create an Empty Project.
3. Create a Software Instrument track.
4. Select the track and play the MPK keys. You should hear the selected patch.
5. Choose a drum kit or electronic kit and press pads 1-8.
6. Turn on the metronome and count-in before recording.
7. Use Smart Controls for filter, tone, reverb, and delay. If a knob does not map cleanly, use the mouse for that pass and keep moving.

8.1.1 GarageBand With the MOTU M4

Use this when you record voice, instruments, or a guide vocal.

Step	GarageBand setting
1	Connect the M4 to the Mac and listen through the M4.
2	Open GarageBand > Settings > Audio/MIDI.
3	Set Input Device to the MOTU M4.
4	Set Output Device to the MOTU M4.
5	Create an Audio track for mic or line input.
6	Select the correct input: 1/2 for front mic inputs, 3/4 for rear line inputs if available.
7	Record a 10-second test and play it back before doing a real take.

8.1.2 GarageBand Starter Layout

Use one row per musical job. This pattern scales when you add a new DAW later: the DAW gets a subsection, and the table stays vertical.

Track	GarageBand place		MPK job
Source	Audio track or imported file		Listen, trim, and align to the grid.
Drums	Software Instrument	with electronic kit	Pads 1-4 play kick, snare/clap, hats, open hat.
Bass	Software Instrument	with synth bass	Lower keys play root/fifth/octave lines.
Chords	Software Instrument	with piano, organ, strings, or pad	Middle keys play stabs or long chords.
Hook	Software Instrument	with lead synth or sampler	Upper keys play answer phrases.
FX	Smart Controls	or audio regions	Knobs/mouse record filter, reverb, delay, risers.

GarageBand's limitation is that it is not a clip-launching DAW. Treat it as a pass-by-pass recorder: record a region, loop it, add the next track, and use the timeline as the arrangement.

8.2 Ableton Live

Ableton Live is the strongest path when you want visible loop launching, source warping, deep MIDI mapping, and clip-to-arrangement performance capture.

1. Connect the MPK over USB.
2. Open Live and create a new Set.
3. Open Settings > Link, Tempo & MIDI.
4. In MIDI Ports, enable Track for the MPK input so keys and pads can play instruments.
5. Enable Remote for the MPK input so knobs and pads can be MIDI-mapped to Live controls.
6. Create a MIDI track, load Drum Rack, and play pads 1-8.
7. Create another MIDI track, load a bass or piano instrument, and play the keys.
8. Press Cmd+M to enter MIDI Map Mode, click a visible control such as a track volume or Auto Filter cutoff, move an MPK knob, then press Cmd+M again.

8.2.1 Ableton Live With the MOTU M4

Use this as your Live setup checklist.

Step	Ableton Live setting
1	Connect the M4 to the Mac and listen through the M4.
2	Open Live > Settings > Audio.
3	Set Audio Input Device to the MOTU M4.
4	Set Audio Output Device to the MOTU M4.
5	Choose a low buffer while recording; raise it later if the project crackles.
6	Enable the input channels you plan to use in Input Config.
7	Create an Audio track.
8	Choose Ext. In: 1/2 for front mic inputs, 3/4 for rear line inputs fed by the Pre-73.
9	Set Monitor to Off for M4 direct monitoring, or Auto if you need Live effects.
10	Arm the track, record a 10-second test, and play it back.

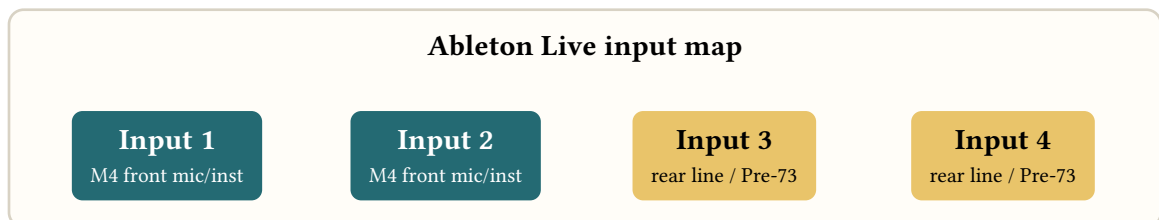


Figure 5: In Ableton Live, M4 hardware inputs appear as Ext. In channel choices.

If the armed Ableton track shows a meter but you hear nothing, check Monitor and the M4's monitor mix. If the M4 meter moves but Ableton does not, the wrong Ext. In channel is probably selected. If Ableton records but playback comes from Mac speakers, the output device is not set to the M4.

8.2.2 Ableton Live Starter Layout

Use Session View as the practice grid:

Track	Device or source	MPK job
1 Source	Audio clip from the video or extracted WAV	Pads can launch source chops later.
2 Drums	Drum Rack	Pads 1-4 play kick, snare, hats, percussion.
3 Bass	Bass instrument	Keys play root/fifth lines.
4 Chords	Piano, organ, or pad instrument	Keys play stabs or long chords.
5 Chops	Simpler or Drum Rack with source slices	Pads 5-8 trigger hooks, fills, and one-shots.
A Reverb	Return track with reverb	Knob controls send amount.
B Delay	Return track with delay	Knob controls one-shot throws.

Record rough musical ideas as clips first. When the clips work, press the global record button and launch scenes or individual clips while Live captures the performance into Arrangement View.

8.3 FL Studio

FL Studio works well if you like patterns, drum grids, quick MIDI editing, and clip-style arranging. On Mac, treat the M4 as the audio device and the MPK as a MIDI input.

1. Connect the M4 to the Mac and connect headphones/monitors to the M4.
2. Connect the MPK mini to the Mac over USB.
3. Open FL Studio.
4. Open Options > Audio settings, or press F10 and choose the Audio tab.
5. In Input/output, select the MOTU M4/Core Audio device.
6. Set a small buffer for recording; raise it later if the project crackles.
7. Open Options > MIDI settings, or press F10 and choose MIDI.
8. In the Input list, select the MPK mini and enable it.
9. Confirm the MIDI activity light blinks when you play keys, pads, or knobs.
10. Add a Channel Rack instrument such as a drum plugin, sampler, FLEX, or a synth, then play the MPK.

For microphone recording in FL Studio on macOS, make sure macOS allows FL Studio to access the microphone/audio input. Then choose the correct M4 input on a Mixer insert before recording.

8.3.1 FL Studio With the MOTU M4

Step	FL Studio setting
1	Connect the M4 to the Mac and listen through the M4.
2	Open Options > Audio settings, or press F10 and choose Audio.
3	Select the MOTU M4/Core Audio device.
4	Set a small buffer for recording; raise it later if the project crackles.
5	Choose the correct M4 input on a Mixer insert before recording audio.
6	Arm the Mixer insert, record a 10-second test, and play it back.

8.3.2 FL Studio Starter Layout

Think in patterns first and Playlist arrangement second:

Track or pattern	FL Studio place	MPK job
Source	Audio clip in Playlist	Trim and align to the song grid.
Drums	Channel Rack, FPC, or drum sampler	Pads 1-4 play kick, snare/clap, hats, open hat.
Bass	Instrument channel routed to Mixer	Lower keys play root/fifth/octave lines.
Chords	Instrument channel or FLEX patch	Middle keys play stabs or long chords.
Hook	Synth, sampler, or audio clip	Upper keys or pads trigger answer phrases.
FX	Automation clips and Mixer effects	Link controls or draw filter, reverb, delay moves.

FL Studio's strength is pattern variation. Make Pattern 1 drums, Pattern 2 bass, Pattern 3 chords, then arrange those patterns in the Playlist.

9 DAW Path Summary

Each DAW now has its own subsection and its own vertical tables. Add a new DAW by copying this pattern: setup checklist, audio-interface checklist, starter layout, then a short note about that DAW's strongest workflow.

DAW	Best reason to use it
GarageBand	Fastest beginner path and the only DAW used by the interactive tutorials.
Ableton Live	Best for clip launching, MIDI mapping, warping, and visible loop performance.
FL Studio	Best for pattern-based arranging, Channel Rack drums, and quick variations.

Do one sanity test in every DAW: open one piano instrument and play the keys. If that works, the MPK is alive. Then test pads with a drum kit. Then test a knob with one visible parameter.

10 DAW Basics

A DAW has five zones: tracks, timeline, mixer, browser, and transport.

Zone	What it does
Tracks	One row per sound: source clip, drums, bass, chords, lead, voice, FX.
Timeline	Time moves left to right. Bars and beats organize the music.
Mixer	Volume, pan, mute, solo, sends, and plugins.
Browser	Instruments, samples, loops, presets, and files.
Transport	Play, stop, record, tempo, metronome, loop range.

Name tracks immediately. Kick, Snare, Source Clip, and Bass teach you more than Audio 1 and MIDI 7.

Save project versions:

- 01_import
- 02_tempo
- 03_drums
- 04_bass_chords
- 05_arrangement
- 06_mix
- 07_video_sync

11 Source Clip Preparation

The source clip is the heart of the remix. Spend more time choosing the right moment than choosing the snare sample.

Good source material has at least one of these:

- A phrase that repeats naturally.
- A rhythm you can tap with your hand.
- A melody that suggests a key.
- A funny, surprising, emotional, or beautiful visual.
- Space between phrases where your music can answer.

Avoid source clips where every second is dense. If the clip is already full of music, talking, crowd noise, and effects, it will be hard to add anything clean.

Practical source workflow:

1. Put the original file in Source Video.
2. Create a copy for editing, never your only original.
3. Extract or import the audio into the DAW.
4. Mark the best phrase.
5. Cut a two-bar or four-bar loop.
6. Add fades so the loop does not click.
7. Save a project version before warping.

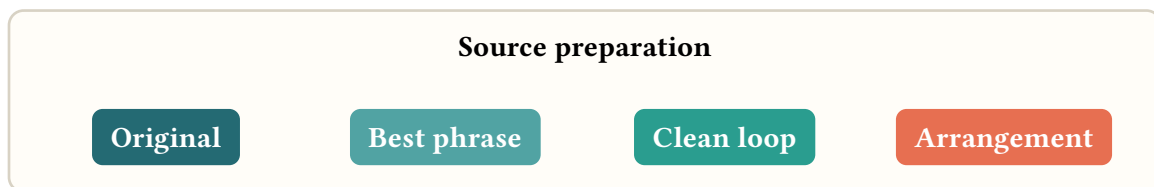


Figure 6: Prepare the source before writing extra parts.

12 MPK Mapping for Remix Work

Map only what you will actually touch during performance.

Control	Suggested beginner mapping
Pad 1	Kick
Pad 2	Snare or clap
Pad 3	Closed hi-hat
Pad 4	Open hi-hat
Pad 5	Percussion or shaker
Pad 6	Source clip chop
Pad 7	Transition hit
Pad 8	Crash, riser, or stop effect
Knob 1	Drum group volume
Knob 2	Bass volume
Knob 3	Chords volume
Knob 4	Lead volume
Knob 5	Filter cutoff
Knob 6	Reverb send
Knob 7	Delay send
Knob 8	Master/performance macro

Good mapping sentence: “I want my left hand to open the filter while my right hand plays the hook.” If you cannot say the sentence, do not map it yet.

12.1 Performance Knob Map

Use this as a stable performance map for the first month. You can change it later, but consistency will teach your hands where everything lives.

Knob	Assign to	Start position	Performance move
K1	Drum bus volume	75%	Pull down for source-only intro; push up at groove entrance.
K2	Bass volume	70%	Bring in after the source hook is understood.
K3	Chord/pad volume	50%	Fade up under emotional vocal notes.
K4	Lead/hook volume	60%	Lift only when answering the source phrase.
K5	Low-pass filter cut-off	35%	Open over 2 or 4 bars into a drop.
K6	Reverb send	10%	Momentary lift on final words or transition hits.
K7	Delay send	0%	Throw one word or stab into a break.
K8	Master performance macro	50%	Map later to a combined filter/saturation/width move.

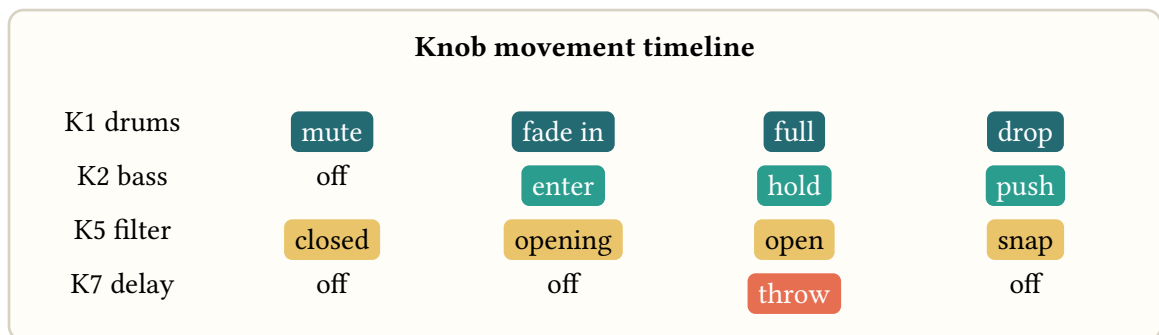


Figure 7: A simple four-section knob plan for intro, entrance, build, and drop.

13 Drum Programming on Pads

Finger drumming does not need to be flashy. For remix production, the goal is a reliable groove.

Start with this pad layout:

Pad	Sound	Why
1	Kick	Main pulse.
2	Snare	Backbeat.
3	Closed hat	Constant motion.
4	Open hat	Lift before changes.
5	Clap	Layer with snare for width.
6	Percussion	Style-specific flavor.
7	Crash	Section marker.
8	Vocal chop or hit	Source-related ear candy.

Record drums in layers instead of all at once:

1. Kick only.
2. Snare/clap.
3. Hats.
4. Percussion.
5. Fills.

This makes editing easier. It also teaches you which part is actually causing a timing problem.

13.1 Pad Timing Grid

Count a four-beat bar as “1 e and a 2 e and a 3 e and a 4 e and a”. Start with these hits:

Count	Pad	Sound
1	Pad 1	Kick
1 and	Pad 3	Closed hat
2	Pad 2	Snare or clap
2 and	Pad 3	Closed hat
3	Pad 1	Kick
3 and	Pad 3	Closed hat
4	Pad 2	Snare or clap
4 and	Pad 4	Open hat or lift

Once that is steady, add Pad 6 on the gap after a source phrase, not during the phrase. This keeps the source intelligible.

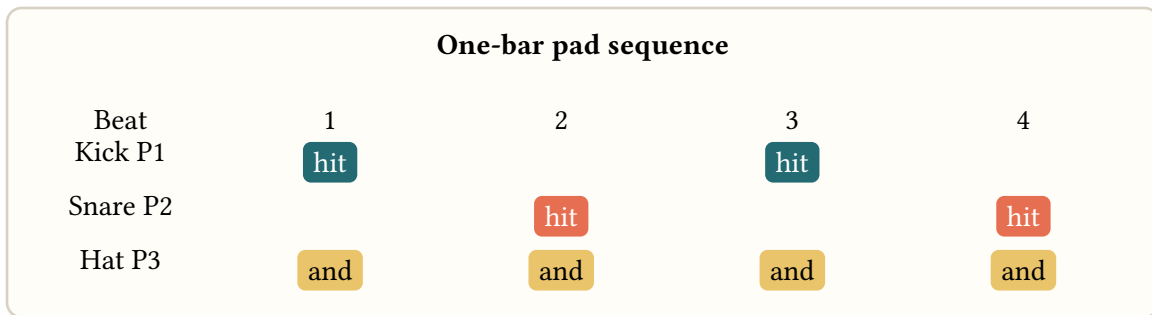


Figure 8: A first dance pattern using only three pads.

14 Playing Bass and Chords on Mini Keys

Mini keys are small, but they are enough for writing. Do not try to play like a concert pianist at first. Use them as a sketchpad.

For bass:

- Find the root note that sounds stable under the source phrase.
- Play fewer notes than you think.
- Make the bass agree with the kick.
- Use octave jumps for energy.
- Use passing notes only near the end of a bar.

For chords:

- Start with triads: major, minor, suspended.
- Hold chords under long vocal notes.
- Use short offbeat stabs for dance energy.
- If the source vocal is busy, use fewer chords.

When in doubt, play the root note in the bass and a simple minor or major chord above it. A simple correct part beats a clever crowded one.

15 A 16-Bar Remix Performance Sequence

This is the practical heart of the workflow. It tells you what to record or perform over 16 bars. Use it slowly at first, then make it musical.

Bars	Source/video	Pads	Keys	Knobs	Record/film
1-2	Source clip alone	None	None	K1 drums down, K5 filter closed	Show source premise.
3-4	Source loop repeats	P3 light hats only	Hold root note quietly	K3 chords low	Film listening/reaction.
5-8	Groove starts	P1 kick, P2 clap, P3 hats	Bass root/fifth pattern	K1 drums up, K2 bass up	Film MPK pads.
9-10	Source phrase re-turns	Keep beat simple	Chord pad under long words	K5 slowly opens	Film keys/knobs.
11-12	Build	Add P4 open hats, P7 riser/crash	Bass octave lift	K6 reverb slightly up	Film knob sweep.
13-16	Drop/payoff	Full pad pattern, P6 chop answer	Bass + hook answer	K5 open, K7 delay throw at bar 16	Film source + performance cuts.

15.1 Bar-by-Bar Beginner Script

Bar	Action
1	Press play on the source loop. Do not play yet. Let the viewer understand it.
2	Nod/count silently. Confirm the loop feels steady.
3	Tap Pad 3 hats on the offbeats. Keep them soft.
4	Add a quiet chord or bass root if the key is obvious.
5	Start Pad 1 kick on beats 1 and 3.
6	Add Pad 2 clap/snare on beats 2 and 4.
7	Add bass notes that line up with the kick.
8	Add a tiny fill with Pad 5 or Pad 6 at the end.
9	Bring source phrase back to the front. Do not overplay.
10	Turn K5 filter slowly upward.
11	Add open hat or shaker.
12	Turn K6 reverb up briefly on the last word.
13	Full drums, full bass, clear hook.
14	Play the answer phrase on keys.
15	Repeat the best musical idea, not a new one.
16	Use K7 delay throw, then stop or cut to source reaction.

The first time, record this as separate passes. Later, perform more of it live.

15.2 DAW Versions of the 16 Bars

Use the same music plan in every DAW, but keep the instructions vertical. A new DAW should become a new subsection below, not another column in a wide table.

15.2.1 GarageBand Version of the 16 Bars

GarageBand records the sequence as timeline regions. This is the model used by the interactive tutorials.

Musical part	GarageBand place	Performance move
Source clip audio	Audio track in Tracks view	Trim the phrase, loop it, and align it to the bar grid.
Kick/snare/hats	Software Instrument drum kit	Finger-drum pads 1-4 into a two-bar MIDI region.
Bass	Software Instrument synth bass	Record a lower-key bass region.
Chords/pads	Software Instrument piano, organ, strings, or pad	Record long chords or offbeat stabs.
Source chops or hits	Audio regions or sampler-style instrument	Place hits at bar 8, 12, or 16.
Knob/filter move	Smart Controls or automation	Record or draw one filter opening into the build.
Reverb/delay throw	Smart Controls, track automation, or effect preset	Add only at section edges.
Final arrangement	Tracks view timeline	Duplicate, mute, and trim regions into the final 16 bars.

GarageBand is not a clip launcher, so the MPK pads are musical events and camera cues. The arrangement itself lives in the timeline.

15.2.2 Ableton Live Version of the 16 Bars

Think in clips first and Arrangement second. The clip grid is the rehearsal space; the Arrangement is the clean performance record.

Musical part	Ableton Live place	Performance move
Source clip audio	Audio clip in Session View, then Arrangement View	Warp the phrase so it loops against the metronome.
Kick/snare/hats	Drum Rack on a MIDI track	Finger-drum pads 1-4 into a two-bar clip.
Bass	MIDI track with a bass instrument	Record a short clip from the lower keys.
Chords/pads	MIDI track with piano, organ, or pad	Record long chords or offbeat stabs.
Source chops	Simpler, Drum Rack, or sliced audio clips	Trigger pads 5-8 for hooks and fills.
Knob filter move	Auto Filter mapped to an MPK knob	Record the sweep into Arrangement automation.
Reverb/delay throw	Return tracks A/B or track sends	Map sends to knobs and move them only at section edges.
Final arrangement	Arrangement View	Capture Session launches, then edit the best take.

Clip or scene	Bars	Contains	Trigger/arrange
Scene 1 - Source	1-4	Warped source phrase only	Let the premise breathe before adding drums.
Scene 2 - Hats	3-16	P3 closed hats, optional P4 open hat	Launch with Global Quantization at 1 Bar.
Scene 3 - Core beat	5-16	P1 kick, P2 clap/snare, P3 hats	Record a Drum Rack clip, then duplicate it.
Scene 4 - Bass	5-16	Root/fifth bass notes from MPK keys	Keep the clip short and loopable.
Scene 5 - Chords	9-16	Sustained chords or offbeat stabs	Fade or filter into the build.
Scene 6 - Fills/chops	8, 12, 16	P5/P6/P7 fills, source hit, crash	Trigger only at section edges.
Automation - Filter	9-13	Low-pass opening	Map Auto Filter cut-off and record the sweep.
Automation - Delay	16	Delay send throw	Move the send up for one beat, then back down.

Set Global Quantization to 1 Bar while learning so clip launches land cleanly. Later, use shorter quantization for fills if the performance needs more immediacy.

15.2.3 FL Studio Version of the 16 Bars

If you choose FL Studio instead, think in patterns first and Playlist arrangement second. Route drums, bass, chords, and source audio to separate Mixer inserts early so the M4-recorded mic, the source clip, and the MPK instruments are easier to balance.

Musical part	FL Studio place	Performance move
Source clip audio	Audio clip in Playlist	Trim, stretch, or slice the phrase to the bar grid.
Kick/snare/hats	Channel Rack, FPC, or drum sampler	Finger-drum pads 1-4 into a drum pattern.
Bass	Instrument channel routed to Mixer	Record lower-key bass into a pattern.
Chords/pads	Instrument channel or FLEX patch	Record chord pattern or long pad notes.
Source chops	Sampler channels or sliced audio	Trigger or place hits at pattern endings.
Knob filter move	Linked control or automation clip	Record or draw the sweep into Playlist automation.
Reverb/delay throw	Mixer effect automation	Automate send or wet level only at section edges.
Final arrangement	Playlist	Place patterns and automation clips into the 16-bar form.

Pattern or clip	Bars	Contains	Trigger/arrange
Pattern 1 - Drums	5-16	Kick, clap/snare, hats	Place in Playlist from the groove entrance onward.
Pattern 2 - Bass	5-16	Root/fifth bass line	Keep short and duplicate.
Pattern 3 - Chords	9-16	Pad or stabs	Bring in after the groove is clear.
Pattern 4 - Fills	8, 12, 16	Crash, tom, source hit, riser	Place only at section edges.
Automation - Filter	9-13	Low-pass opening	Draw the sweep as an automation clip.
Automation - Delay	16	Delay throw	Raise for one beat, then return to dry.

16 Rhythm, Tempo, and Sync

The source clip must agree with the project tempo. Even a comic remix needs a serious clock.

1. Import the source video or source audio.
2. Find the best two-bar or four-bar phrase.
3. Tap tempo while listening.
4. Loop the phrase against the metronome.
5. If it drifts, warp, flex, or slice the audio.
6. Build drums only after the source loop is stable.

Problem	Fix
Source rushes ahead	Add warp/flex markers or slice phrases to the grid.
Tempo feels wrong	Try half-time or double-time. 92 BPM may feel like 184 BPM.
Drums sound stiff	Use swing, velocity variation, and lighter quantization.
Loop clicks	Add tiny fades at region edges.

17 Quantization, Swing, and Human Feel

Quantization moves MIDI notes toward the grid. It can fix sloppy timing, but it can also remove personality.

Use these settings as a mindset:

Material	Quantize amount
Kick in club beat	Strong quantize is usually fine.
Snare/clap	Mostly tight, with small variation if desired.
Hi-hats	Quantize, then vary velocity.
Percussion	Lighter quantize; keep some human push/pull.
Bass	Tight to kick, but not robotic.
Chords	Depends on style; stabs can be tight, pads can be loose.
Source clip	Warp only as much as needed to make the groove work.

Swing shifts some subdivisions later, creating bounce. Try small swing amounts before you rewrite a pattern. If a groove feels technically correct but boring, vary velocity first, then try swing, then change notes.

18 Recording Instruments and Voice

Kiffness-style production often feels like one person building a tiny band around a clip.

Source	How to record it
MPK keys	Create an instrument track, choose a sound, arm, record MIDI.
MPK pads	Create a drum/sampler track, map pads, record MIDI hits.
Voice	Use a USB mic or audio interface; monitor with wired headphones.
Guitar or bass	Plug into an interface; record dry if you want to change amp sound later.
Percussion	Mic real claps/shakers or use samples. Real layers help programmed drums.

Record at healthy levels. Peaks around -12 dB to -6 dB are fine. If the waveform looks like a rectangle, it clipped; turn down the input and record again.

19 Microphones, Interfaces, and Monitoring

For voice, acoustic instruments, and room percussion, the recording chain is:

Voice/instrument -> microphone -> audio interface -> Mac/DAW -> headphones

If you use a USB microphone, the mic and interface are combined:

Voice/instrument -> USB microphone -> Mac/DAW -> headphones

Monitoring means hearing yourself while recording. If monitoring is delayed, you will play or sing late. Fixes:

- Use wired headphones.
- Lower the DAW buffer size while recording.
- Close CPU-heavy apps.
- Use direct monitoring on an audio interface when available.
- Record dry and add reverb after the take if latency is distracting.

Room noise matters. Turn off fans when possible. Stay close enough to the mic that your voice is stronger than the room.

20 Drums, Bass, Chords, and Hooks

Each layer has a job.

Layer	Job
Kick	Defines dance pulse.
Snare/clap	Gives the backbeat.
Hi-hats	Add motion and subdivision.
Percussion	Adds style and regional feel.
Bass	Connects drums to harmony.
Chords	Add emotion without crowding the source.
Lead/hook	Answers the source phrase.

Beginner two-bar pattern:

```

Beat:  1      2      3      4
Kick:  X          X
Clap:           X      X
Hat:   x  x  x  x  x  x  x  x
Bass:  root      fifth root walk

```

Start with drums and bass only. If that does not work, extra layers will not rescue it.

21 Arrangement Blueprint

A short remix still needs structure. Even 45 seconds can have a beginning, middle, and payoff.

Section	Length	Job
Cold open	2-5 seconds	Show the source premise immediately.
Setup loop	4-8 bars	Let the source hook repeat cleanly.
Groove entrance	4-8 bars	Add drums and bass.
Build	2-4 bars	Filter, riser, snare fill, or visual setup.
Drop/payoff	8-16 bars	Full remix energy.
Tag ending	1-4 bars	Punchline, delay throw, stop, or source reaction.

Kiffness-style videos often feel spontaneous, but the arrangement is doing real work. The viewer is being taught the source, shown the transformation, and then rewarded with the full version.

22 Mixing From Zero

Mixing is deciding what the listener should notice first, second, and third.

1. Pull every fader down.
2. Bring up the source clip or lead vocal until it is clear.
3. Add kick and bass.
4. Add snare/clap and hats.
5. Add chords and hook instruments.
6. Add reverb, delay, risers, and fills last.
7. Check on headphones and laptop speakers.

Tool	Beginner use
Volume	The main mix control. Use this before plugins.
Pan	Move support parts away from the center.
EQ	Remove mud and make room for voice.
Compression	Smooth levels or add punch. Use gently.
Reverb	Adds space. Too much pushes sounds away.
Delay	Rhythmic repeats, transition throws, endings.
Limiter	Prevents export clipping on the master.

Simple EQ starting point: high-pass non-bass instruments around 80 to 150 Hz, cut a little mud around 200 to 400 Hz if needed, and add presence around 2 to 5 kHz only when a sound needs clarity.

23 Effects That Make Remixes Feel Finished

Use effects as musical punctuation.

Effect	Use it for	Beginner warning
Filter sweep	Build into a drop or reveal a loop.	Do not leave every part filtered forever.
Reverb throw	Make one word or hit bloom.	Too much reverb makes the mix blurry.
Delay throw	Echo the last word before a break.	Time it to the project tempo.
Saturation	Add warmth and density.	Easy to overdo; compare before/after.
Sidechain compression	Make pads/bass pulse with kick.	Subtle is often better.
Riser/noise sweep	Signal a section change.	Keep it short in comedy or meme edits.

Record effect moves with knobs. A visible knob turn is both an audio event and a video event.

24 Syncing Music to Video

The picture should feel musical.

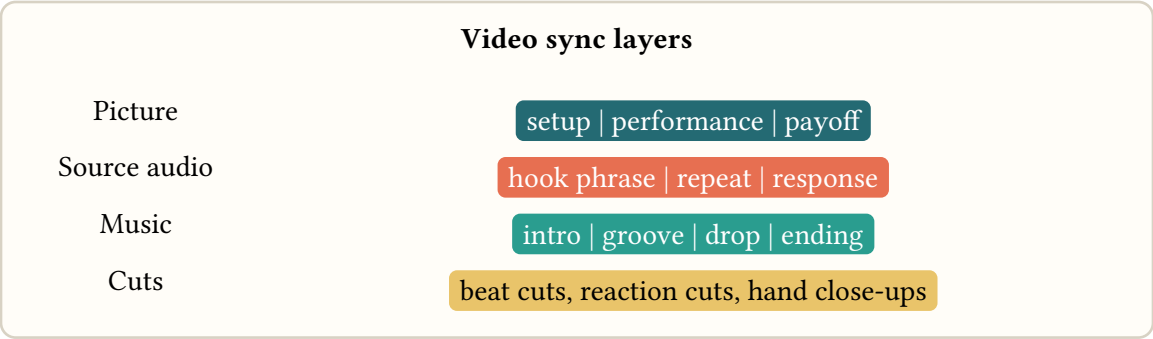


Figure 9: Treat the video edit as another rhythmic layer.

Use a clap, visible consonant, drum transient, or hand motion as a sync anchor. Cut to the source clip when it sings or speaks the hook. Cut to the MPK when a new layer enters. Export a short test before rendering the final version.

25 Export Settings

For learning, export often. Do not wait until a project is perfect before checking a render.

Audio export targets:

Use	Format
DAW mix for video editor	WAV or AIFF, 24-bit if available.
Quick sharing draft	MP3 or AAC.
Final video upload	Let the video editor encode audio with the video.

Video export targets:

Platform	Practical starting point
YouTube horizontal	1920 x 1080, 24/30 fps, H.264 or H.265.
Shorts/Reels/TikTok	1080 x 1920 vertical, 30 fps, H.264 or H.265.
Archive master	Highest quality your editor can reasonably store.

Always watch the exported file, not only the DAW timeline. Exports can reveal sync errors, missing fonts, muted tracks, clipping, and wrong aspect ratios.

26 Case Study: Im Hashem Lo Yivneh Bayis

This reference shows how a choir phrase can become the emotional center of a dance remix.

Element	Study notes
Source role	The choir provides the hook and harmonic identity.
Production goal	Support the vocal phrase with a dance pulse without burying the choir.
MPK use	Pads for drums, keys for bass/chords, knobs for filter and reverb build.
Practice version	Use your own sung phrase or a licensed choir-like sample.

Practice steps:

1. Choose a two-bar vocal or choir phrase with emotional lift.
2. Find the key by playing notes under it until one feels like home.
3. Program a four-on-the-floor kick.
4. Add clap/snare on beats 2 and 4.
5. Play a bass root on beat 1 and a passing note before beat 3.
6. Add warm chords under long syllables.
7. Open a filter or reverb send into the drop.

26.1 Choir Remix Pad/Knob Sequence

Bars	Pads	Keys	Knobs	Goal
1-2	None	Find and hold root quietly	K1 down, K3 low	Let the choir be the hook.
3-4	P3 hats only	Soft chord pad	K3 fade up	Add lift without stealing focus.
5-8	P1 four-on-floor, P2 clap	Bass on root and fifth	K1 and K2 up	Convert choir phrase into dance pulse.
9-12	Add P5 shaker	Chord inversions	K5 opens slowly	Build anticipation.
13-16	P7 crash at bar 13, P6 vocal chop answer	Hook answer melody	K6 reverb on final syllable	Payoff and emotional bloom.
17	Stop drums	None	K7 delay throw	Let the last choir word echo.

For choir-like material, reverb is tempting. Use it as a moment, not as fog. The source already has space and harmony; your mix should preserve the words.

27 Case Study: Ievan Polkka

This reference is a strong study in turning a viral performance into a club arrangement.

Element	Study notes
Source role	The melody and performance personality are already strong.
Production goal	Make the source danceable without losing its playful identity.
MPK use	Pads for kick/snare/hat, keys for bass, note repeat for hats, knobs for delay throws.
Practice version	Use a public-domain folk melody or your own whistled phrase.

Fast folk melodies often work over a simpler club foundation. Do not make every part busy. Use bass to translate the melody into dance music. Place percussion fills in the gaps between phrases.

27.1 Folk/Club Remix Pad/Knob Sequence

Bars	Pads	Keys	Knobs	Goal
1-2	None	None	K1 down	Let the source melody introduce itself.
3-4	P3 hats with Note Repeat	Root pulse	K5 half closed	Hint at tempo.
5-8	P1 kick, P2 clap, P3 hats	Root-fifth-octave bass	K1/K2 up	Make it club-readable.
9-12	P5 percussion between phrases	Short chord stabs	K7 tiny delay on phrase endings	Keep motion playful.
13-16	P4 open hat, P7 crash	Bass octaves	K5 opens, K8 macro up	Drop without crowding the melody.
17-20	P6 source chop answer	Simple lead response	K7 delay throw at the end	Turn the source into call-and-response.

If the melody is fast, your hands should play less. Let the source do the gymnastics while the MPK supplies weight and shape.

28 Case Study: Insomnia

This reference points toward live-looping energy: build the track in visible layers so viewers can feel each entrance.

Element	Study notes
Source role	The Balkan musical character supplies rhythm, melodic flavor, and visual identity.
Production goal	Layer club drums under regional rhythm without flattening the feel.
MPK use	Pads for layered percussion, keys for stabs and bass, knobs for buildup effects.
Practice version	Record claps, a short vocal phrase, or a hand-played melody.

Lock the downbeat, but do not destroy all timing personality. Some music feels right because it leans ahead or relaxes behind the grid.

28.1 Balkan/Live-Loop Pad/Knob Sequence

Bars	Pads	Keys	Knobs	Goal
1-2	P5 hand percussion only	None	K1 low	Establish human rhythm.
3-4	Add P1 kick under percussion	Root drone	K2 barely up	Lock the downbeat.
5-8	P2 clap/snare, P3 hats	Offbeat chord stabs	K3 up	Blend club pulse with regional feel.
9-12	P6 source hit in gaps	Bass answer phrase	K5 opens	Build the loop visibly.
13-16	P4 open hat, P7 crash	Full bass + stabs	K6 small reverb lift	Full loop payoff.
17-20	Strip back to P5 then re-enter	Short lead answer	K7 delay throw	Create a break and return.

For this style, avoid quantizing every percussion hit to perfection. Keep the kick reliable, then let supporting percussion breathe.

29 Live Looping and Performance Capture

Even if the final video is edited, practice live looping because it teaches fast decisions.

Loop layer	Performance tip
Drum loop	Record two bars; quantize lightly.
Bass loop	Keep it short and repeatable.
Chord loop	Use long notes or offbeat stabs.
Hook answer	Play a tiny phrase that comments on the source.
FX pass	Record knob movement after the notes are solid.

Film hands, face, source clip, and DAW separately if needed. Record audio directly in the DAW, not through the camera mic.

30 Video Editing for Music Producers

Your edit should prove that the music is interacting with the source.

Shot	Purpose
Source clip	Shows the premise.
MPK close-up	Shows pads, keys, and knob moves creating musical events.
DAW screen	Optional proof of layering. Use sparingly.
Face/performance	Adds reaction and humor.
Wide desk shot	Establishes the real setup.

The first five seconds matter. Make the premise obvious, then let the musical build carry the rest.

31 Copyright, Collaboration, and Credits

Remix culture thrives on reference and transformation, but public uploads can still run into copyright claims, takedowns, or blocked monetization.

Safer source choices:

- Your own videos and recordings.
- A friend's clip used with written permission.
- Public-domain recordings.
- Creative Commons material where the license allows remixing.
- Paid sample packs and licensed loops.

Good credit habits:

- Keep source URLs and permission notes in the project folder.
- Credit collaborators clearly.
- Do not imply endorsement by the original creator.
- If someone asks you to remove their clip, take the request seriously.

For practice, you can make private remixes that never leave your computer. For public release, think like both a musician and a publisher.

32 Practice Projects

Project	Goal
One phrase, one beat	Take a legal two-bar phrase and build drums only.
Bass translation	Add a bass line that makes the phrase feel like a song.
Knob performance	Map filter and reverb, then record automation.
Live layer video	Film yourself adding drums, bass, and chords.
Full remix sketch	Make a 45-second intro, drop, break, and ending.

Four-week plan:

- Week 1: MPK, MIDI, tempo, tracks, and simple drums.
- Week 2: three 15-second remixes from your own voice memos.
- Week 3: video sync and camera angles.
- Week 4: one finished 45 to 60 second remix.

33 Case Study: What Is Love Live Loop in GarageBand

Reference: MunomaMusic - Haddaway - What Is Love (Live Loop Cover) | Minilab 3
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=wK1V8v1UPZo>

This reference is not a Kiffness source-clip remix. It is a straight live-loop cover: a controller, a DAW, a few synth sounds, and a camera angle that lets the viewer see the song being assembled. That makes it a perfect study for learning how to translate a performance from one controller and one DAW into your own setup.

The original video lists Arturia Minilab 3, Ableton Live, Mini V3, Serum, and Ableton stock synths. Your version uses Akai MPK mini IV and GarageBand. The method is the same, but the workflow changes:

Original idea	Your translation
Minilab pads lighting as parts enter Ableton clip/performance workflow	MPK pads 1-8 trigger drums and section cues. GarageBand records one track at a time into regions.
Mini V/Serum synth sounds	GarageBand synth bass, classic synth, and pad patches.
Top-down controller performance	Film your MPK from above, then add one angled desk shot.
Live-loop build	Layer short MIDI regions until the full groove plays.

The song style is 1990s eurodance. Your beginner target is not a perfect cover; it is a recognizable practice arrangement with four jobs:

1. A minor-key hook on the keys.
2. A steady dance drum pattern on pads.
3. A short synth bass line.
4. A pad or chord layer that makes the chorus feel wide.

33.1 GarageBand Project Setup

Create a new GarageBand project and choose Empty Project. Add a Software Instrument track. Set the tempo near 124 BPM, turn on the metronome, and turn on count-in. If 124 feels slightly off for your hands, use 122 or 126 while practicing, then return to 124 later.

Use this track list:

Track	GarageBand sound	MPK job
1 Drums	Electronic Drum Kit or Drum Machine Designer kit	Pads 1-4 play kick, clap/snare, hat, open hat.
2 Bass	Synth Bass patch	Lower keys play root, fifth, octave.
3 Chords	Classic Synth, Analog Pad, or Bright Pad	Middle keys play minor/major chord stabs.
4 Hook	Lead Synth, Classic Synth Lead, or a bright mono synth	Upper keys play the memorable answer phrase.
5 Sweep FX	Any synth patch with Smart Controls visible	Knobs or mouse record filter/reverb movement.

GarageBand on Mac does not work like Ableton Session View. Think in passes: record a two-bar or four-bar region, loop it, add the next track, and keep going. The viewer still experiences it as live looping if you film each pass cleanly.

33.2 MPK Mini IV Setup

Connect the MPK mini IV directly to the Mac over USB-C. Open Audio MIDI Setup and confirm the device appears. In GarageBand, select a Software Instrument track and play a few keys. If you hear the selected patch, the MPK is working.

Use one stable control map:

MPK control	Use in this study
Pad 1	Kick on beats 1, 2, 3, 4 for four-on-the-floor.
Pad 2	Clap/snare on beats 2 and 4.
Pad 3	Closed hat on offbeats or eighth notes.
Pad 4	Open hat before section changes.
Pad 5	Crash or section accent.
Pad 6	Short vocal-style stab or synth hit.
Pad 7	Riser/noise hit if you add one.
Pad 8	Stop/accent ending.
Keys low octave	Bass line.
Keys middle octave	Chords.
Keys high octave	Hook or lead answer.
Knobs	Smart Controls: filter, resonance, reverb, delay, or track volume.

If GarageBand does not let a knob control the exact parameter you want, do not stall. Use GarageBand Smart Controls with the mouse for the first pass, then graduate to Logic Pro when you want deeper MIDI Learn. The musical study matters more than proving every knob map on day one.

33.3 A Beginner Arrangement

Use a four-section build over 32 bars:

Bars	What the viewer sees	What you record
1-4	MPK keys alone	Hook idea or chord pulse, very sparse.
5-8	Pads begin lighting	Kick, clap, and hat.
9-16	Hands move to lower keys	Synth bass locks to the kick.
17-24	Chords widen the sound	Pad/chord stabs under the hook.
25-32	Full performance	Lead hook, drum fill, open filter, ending accent.

For the bass, begin with a root-fifth-octave shape. For the chords, use simple minor and major triads. If you already know the original progression, use it as a guide. If not, find a minor root that feels stable and build a practice loop around that; the point is controller fluency.

33.4 Recording Order in GarageBand

Record in this order:

1. Drums first. Make a two-bar region with kick, clap, and hats. Quantize only enough to make the groove reliable.
2. Bass second. Use short notes. The bass should agree with the kick more than it should show off.
3. Chords third. Leave room for the hook; wide pads can become blurry fast.
4. Hook fourth. Play the smallest phrase that makes the song recognizable.
5. Effects last. Open a filter or lift reverb only at transitions.

After each pass, listen once before adding the next part. If a new layer makes the groove worse, mute it and fix the previous layer instead of stacking more sounds.

33.5 Video Capture Plan

The reference video teaches through repetition: top-down hands, pads lighting, keys moving, then a wider desk angle near the end. Recreate that language with your own camera:

Shot	Use it for
Top-down MPK	Main proof that pads, keys, and wheels are performing the track.
GarageBand screen	One short insert showing the five named tracks and loop regions.
Angled desk shot	Final full-loop performance when the arrangement is complete.
Close-up on pads	Drum entrance and ending accent.
Close-up on keys	Bass and hook entrances.

Do not use the camera microphone for the final sound. Export the GarageBand mix and sync that audio to the video edit. A visible pad hit, key press, or count-in click gives you a sync anchor.

33.6 GarageBand Limits and Upgrade Path

GarageBand is enough for this practice cover, but it is not a perfect live-loop substitute for Ableton Live. Its strength is simple recording and editing. Its weakness is hands-on clip launching and deep MIDI mapping. When this study starts to feel constrained, move the same project idea to Logic Pro Live Loops or Ableton Live.

The successful GarageBand version is simple: five tracks, two or four bars per region, a visible MPK performance, and a clear build from thin to full. Finish that before chasing exact synth presets.

34 Case Study: Don't Cry Tonight John E.S Remix in Garage-Band

Reference: Savage & John.E.S - Don t cry tonight (The official remix)

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=zuHLHvZv4Ac>

This reference is a full remix study rather than a controller live-loop demo. It is useful because it teaches a different skill: how to make an 1980s Italo-disco song feel modern while preserving the vocal drama, wide synths, and steady dance pulse.

The video is built from performance and montage footage: stage lights, singer close-ups, keyboard shots, dancers, live-band inserts, and a graphic outro. Your GarageBand version should not try to recreate the exact video. Recreate the music language first, then film your own MPK performance as proof that you built the layers.

To make the controls more concrete, borrow performance language from MPK-centric cover videos. An Akai MPK/GarageBand cover of “Song for Denise” shows the simplest version: small controller, GarageBand, phone camera, and a clear melody performance. MPK synthwave and 1980s cover videos such as “Nightcall,” “Take On Me,” “Don't You (Forget About Me),” and “Blinding Lights” show the controller role more clearly: pads for drums or section cues, keys for bass and hook, and visible hands to prove the arrangement is playable.

Use those MPK videos for control behavior. Use the John E.S video for song shape, mood, and edit pacing.

Reference ingredient	GarageBand/MPK translation
Long official remix arrangement	Short 64-bar practice edit.
1980s vocal focus	Use a lead-vocal guide track, sung phrase, or legal vocal stand-in.
Four-on-the-floor pulse	MPK pads record kick, snare/clap, hat, and open hat.
Italo bass movement	MPK lower keys play octave bass and passing notes.
Wide synth atmosphere	GarageBand pads, strings, or classic synth chords.
Stage montage	Your edit cuts between MPK, GarageBand regions, and performance shots.

34.1 Project Setup

Create a new GarageBand project and set the tempo around 116-122 BPM. The exact tempo is less important than the feel: steady, mid-tempo dance music with a romantic synth-pop mood. Turn on metronome and count-in while recording.

Use this track list:

Track	GarageBand sound	MPK job
1 Kick	Electronic drum kit	Pad 1 plays four-on-the-floor.
2 Snare/Clap	Electronic drum kit or separate kit track	Pad 2 plays backbeat.
3 Hats	Electronic drum kit	Pads 3 and 4 play closed/open hats.
4 Italo Bass	Synth Bass	Lower keys play octave bass.
5 Chords	Classic Synth, Analog Pad, or Synth Strings	Middle keys hold emotional chords.
6 Lead Hook	Bright synth lead or bell synth	Upper keys play a short answer melody.
7 Vocal Guide	Audio track	Record your own guide phrase or use cleared material.
8 FX	Riser, sweep, reverb, delay	Knobs or Smart Controls shape transitions.

If you do not have a cleared vocal, hum or sing a placeholder phrase. Do not build your practice workflow around unauthorized vocal extraction. The lesson is arrangement and production, not copying a master recording.

34.2 MPK Mini IV Map

Use the MPK as a compact Italo-disco band:

Control	Job	GarageBand target
Pad A1	Kick on every beat.	Kick track or drum-kit kick.
Pad A2	Snare or clap on beats 2 and 4.	Snare/clap track.
Pad A3	Closed hat eighth notes.	Hat track.
Pad A4	Open hat before section changes.	Hat track.
Pad A5	Crash at chorus entry.	FX or drum-kit crash.
Pad A6	Toms or gated fill.	Drum fill region.
Pad A7	Noise sweep or riser.	FX track.
Pad A8	Ending hit or muted stop.	FX/stop accent.
Pad B1	Chorus launch marker.	Visual cue, duplicated chorus region.
Pad B2	Break marker.	Visual cue, muted kick section.
Pad B3	Delay throw cue.	FX automation pass.
Pad B4	Final tag cue.	Ending region.
Lower keys	Octave bass line.	Italo Bass track.
Middle keys	Minor/major chord pads.	Chords track.
Upper keys	Lead answer phrase.	Lead Hook track.
Pitch wheel	Occasional lead bend only.	Lead Hook expression.
Mod wheel	Brightness/vibrato on lead or pad.	Smart Control/tone if available.
Knobs	Filter, tone, reverb, delay, level.	Smart Controls or mouse-recorded automation.

The bass is the center of the style. Start with a root-octave pattern and add passing notes only when the kick and clap already feel solid.

34.3 Better Controls From the MPK References

The most useful lesson from MPK-centric videos is that the controller should look organized. Do not make the viewer guess what your hands are doing. Split the MPK into zones:

Zone	Controls	What the viewer understands
Drum zone	Pads A1-A4	The beat is being played by hand.
Section zone	Pads A5-A8 or Bank B pads	Crashes, risers, breaks, and ending hits mark the arrangement.
Bass zone	Lower keys	The dance engine is being performed, not just pasted in.
Hook zone	Upper keys	The recognizable melody or answer phrase is playable.
Color zone	Wheels and knobs	Filter, reverb, delay, and brightness create the remix lift.

GarageBand cannot launch clips like Ableton, so use pads as recordable musical events and visible section cues. The actual section changes happen in the GarageBand timeline. When you film, cut to the pad at the same moment the region or automation change happens.

Use this knob plan even if you record some moves with the mouse:

Knob	Target	Move
K1	Bass level	Fade bass in during bars 9-16.
K2	Pad filter cutoff	Open slowly through bars 25-32.
K3	Pad or vocal reverb	Lift only at phrase endings.
K4	Delay send	Throw the last word or lead note into the break.
K5	Lead brightness	Push the hook forward in the chorus.
K6	FX/riser level	Bring up before bar 33.
K7	Drum bus level	Pull down during the break, return for final chorus.
K8	Master mood macro	Later, map in Logic; in GarageBand treat this as a reminder.

34.4 A 64-Bar Practice Arrangement

Official remixes are long. Your learning version should be short enough to finish:

Bars	Section	What to build
1-8	Intro	Kick, hat, filtered pad, tiny lead hint.
9-16	Groove	Bass enters with clap/snare.
17-24	Verse feel	Vocal guide or lead phrase enters, drums stay restrained.
25-32	Pre-chorus	Open filter, add pad width, small snare fill.
33-48	Chorus	Full kick/clap/hats, bass, chords, lead answer, reverb lift.
49-56	Break	Remove kick, leave pad and vocal/lead.
57-64	Final chorus/tag	Full groove returns; end with delay throw or stop hit.

This is the point where GarageBand is friendly: each section can be a row of regions in the timeline. Duplicate regions, mute what does not belong, then add one new performance layer at a time.

34.5 Drum Feel

Record drums in separate passes:

1. Kick on every beat.
2. Clap or snare on beats 2 and 4.
3. Closed hat eighth notes.
4. Open hat at the end of every second or fourth bar.
5. A tom, crash, or riser before the chorus.

Quantize the kick and clap fairly tightly. Leave hats slightly lighter in velocity so they do not scrape across the whole mix. If the groove feels flat, change hat velocity before changing the whole pattern.

34.6 Bass and Harmony

For an Italo-style bass line, use one octave and a few strong notes:

Beat	Bass move
1	Root note.
1 and 2	Octave or repeated root.
2	Fifth or root.
3	Root or octave.
4 and	Passing note into the next bar.

Chords should be emotional but not busy. Use long pad chords in the intro and break. Use shorter stabs or sidechain-like volume movement in the chorus if the pad crowds the vocal.

34.7 Vocal or Lead Stand-In

The reference is vocal-centered, so your practice version needs something in the vocal role. Use one of these:

Option	Use when
Sing your own phrase	Best for learning arrangement legally.
Play a lead synth phrase	Good if you do not want to sing yet.
Use a licensed vocal loop	Good for a polished practice demo.
Use the original vocal privately only	Acceptable for personal study; do not publish it without rights.

Keep the vocal or lead phrase dry enough to understand. Add reverb throws only at line endings.

34.8 Mix Shape

Bring the mix up in this order:

1. Vocal or lead guide.
2. Kick.
3. Bass.
4. Clap/snare.
5. Hats.
6. Chords and pads.
7. Lead answer.
8. Reverb, delay, risers, and outro effects.

For this style, the kick and bass can be strong, but the vocal mood must stay in front. High-pass pads and leads so they do not cloud the bass. Use delay as a phrase-ending event, not as a permanent wash.

34.9 Video Plan

Use the reference video's visual grammar without copying its footage:

Shot	Use it for
Red/blue light or simple backdrop	Intro atmosphere.
MPK top-down	Drum and bass programming evidence.
GarageBand screen	Section layout and named tracks.
Keyboard close-up	Lead hook or pad chords.
Vocal/performance shot	Verse and chorus focus.
Wide desk shot	Final chorus with all layers active.
Text/graphic outro	Title card, credits, or project name.

Export the GarageBand audio first. Then cut the video to the rendered mix so the visuals follow the groove. A visible Pad 1 kick hit at bar 33 is a clean sync point for the chorus.

34.10 Reference Stack for This Study

Use these references together:

Reference	What to borrow
John E.S official remix video	Mood, stage montage, vocal focus, long remix energy.
MPK/GarageBand “Song for Denise” cover	Minimal desk setup: MPK, GarageBand, phone camera.
MPK synthwave “Nightcall” style cover	Retro bass, dark pad mood, visible loop performance.
MPK “Take On Me” and “Don’t You” covers	1980s lead-hook confidence on mini keys.
MPK “Blinding Lights” covers	Modern 1980s-style drums, bass, and live-loop energy.

The finished exercise is your own short, playable remix study. It should feel informed by the John E.S track, but the MPK footage should teach how your hands control the groove.

35 Troubleshooting

Symptom	Likely fix
MPK not detected	Try another USB cable/port, avoid hubs, check Audio MIDI Setup, restart DAW.
Keys move meters but no sound	Load an instrument plugin and enable monitoring.
Pads trigger wrong sounds	Load the correct kit or remap pad notes.
Delay while playing	Use wired headphones, lower buffer size, close heavy apps.
Audio distorted	Lower input gain and record again.
Video drifts	Check tempo, warp/flex settings, frame rate, and variable-frame-rate source files.
Export too quiet	Balance the mix, use a limiter, compare at matched volume.

Before panic: create a new empty project with one software piano track. If the MPK plays that, the controller is fine and the problem is inside the original session.

36 Quick Reference

Task	Fast path
Start project	Create folder, import source clip, save version 01_import.
Find tempo	Tap tempo, loop source phrase, align to grid.
Build groove	Kick, clap, hat, bass. Stop before decoration.
Map MPK	Pads to drums; knobs to levels/filter/reverb/delay.
Record	Arm track, count-in, loop section, record multiple takes.
Mix	Balance source, drums, bass, chords, hooks, FX, limiter.
Sync video	Align source audio, cut to beats, export test.
Finish	Listen on headphones and laptop, fix, export final.

37 Sources and Further Learning

Primary reference videos:

- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=EGmXAu8geVg>
- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=CAyWN9ba9J8>
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=hVJtPuuQK_s
- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=wK1V8v1UPZo>
- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=zuHLHvZv4Ac>
- <https://m.youtube.com/watch?v=64XFe3BpOGY>
- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=TvhlfWXRQzk>
- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=K3yjSSj1w7w>
- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=4-IxomkVi-g>
- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=TQWX7uOTFN8>

Akai references used for setup and controller behavior:

- Akai MPK mini MK3 product page: <https://www.akaipro.com/mpk-mini-mk3/>
- Akai MPK mini setup article: <https://support.akaipro.com/en/support/solutions/articles/69000798879-akai-pro-mpk-mini-mpk-mini-play-mpk-mini-plus-how-to-download-install-and-setup-the-included-so>
- Akai MPK mini Plus user guide: <https://cdn.inmusicbrands.com/akai/attachments/mpkminiplus/MPK%20mini%20Plus%20-%20User%20Guide%20-%20v1.2.pdf>

Hardware and DAW references used for the expanded setup:

- Ableton Live MIDI settings: <https://help.ableton.com/hc/en-us/articles/209774205-Live-s-MIDI-Settings>
- Ableton Live MIDI and key remote control: <https://www.ableton.com/en/manual/midi-and-key-remote-control/>
- Ableton Live audio clips, tempo, and warping: <https://www.ableton.com/en/manual/audio-clips-tempo-and-warping/>
- Ableton Live Session View: <https://www.ableton.com/en/manual/session-view/>
- Ableton Live Arrangement View: <https://www.ableton.com/en/manual/arrangement-view/>
- Ableton Live video: <https://www.ableton.com/en/live-manual/12/working-with-video/>
- Apple Audio MIDI Setup for Mac: <https://support.apple.com/guide/audio-midi-setup/set-up-audio-devices-ams59f301fda/mac>
- Apple MIDI Studio setup for Mac: <https://support.apple.com/guide/audio-midi-setup/set-up-midi-devices-ams875bae1e0/mac>
- Apple GarageBand for Mac: Software Instruments: https://education.apple.com/learning-center/T024638A-en_US
- Apple GarageBand for Mac: <https://www.apple.com/mac/garageband/>
- Akai MPK mini IV product page: <https://www.akaipro.com/mpk-mini-4/>
- Akai MPK mini IV user guide: <https://cdn.inmusicbrands.com/akai/mpk-mini-4/MPK%20mini%20IV%20-%20User%20Guide%20-%20v1.1.pdf>
- MOTU M4 product page: <https://motu.com/products/m-series/m4>
- MOTU M4 specifications: <https://motu.com/en-us/products/m-series/m4/specs/>
- Golden Age Audio Pre-73 MKIII: <https://goldenageaudio.com/outboard-hardware/preamps/pre-73-mk-iii/>

- Golden Age Project PRE-73 MKIII manual: https://goldenagemusic.se/home/goldenageproject/manuals/manual_pre73mk3.pdf
- FL Studio audio setup: https://www.image-line.com/fl-studio-learning/fl-studio-online-manual/html/app_wiz2.htm
- FL Studio audio settings: https://www.image-line.com/fl-studio-learning/fl-studio-online-manual/html/envsettings_audio.htm
- FL Studio MIDI settings: https://www.image-line.com/fl-studio-learning/fl-studio-online-manual/html/envsettings_midi.htm
- FL Studio audio recording: https://www.image-line.com/fl-studio-learning/fl-studio-online-manual/html/recording_audio.htm

Search terms for deeper study:

- Ableton Live MPK mini Track Remote
- Ableton Live Session View clip launch
- Ableton Live Arrangement View video
- Ableton Live MIDI Map Mode
- GarageBand MIDI controller setup
- FL Studio MIDI settings MPK mini
- FL Studio audio recording MOTU M4
- Logic Pro Flex Time vocals
- Ableton Live warp audio to tempo
- MPC Beats MPK mini mapping
- DaVinci Resolve audio sync
- beginner EQ compression reverb delay